

Public Speaking at Work

Speak up in meetings and presentations, without panicking

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Speak up in meetings and presentations, without panicking

Presenting to a group, speaking up in a meeting, defending an idea: for many, it's fear number one. Racing heart, shaky voice, blank mind. The good news: public speaking isn't a gift, it's a skill you can build.

This guide helps you understand your fear, ease the nerves, and express yourself with clarity and presence — even if you weren't 'born for it'.

Your intention

A speaking situation that stresses you: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

Where your fear of the gaze comes from

Fear of public speaking is rarely 'irrational': it's rooted in fear of judgment, sometimes past mockery, or the belief 'I have nothing interesting to say'.

Understanding the origin means no longer mistaking your fear for a truth about your abilities.

Example

Mocked at school when he spoke up, Tom avoided all presentations. Linking the fear to that memory helped him defuse it.

My history with the gaze

When did I learn to fear speaking in front of others?

What I have to say

List 3 topics where you have real value to offer.

→ *My fear of the gaze comes from my history — not a lack of legitimacy.*

The thoughts that paralyze

‘Everyone will see I’m stressed’, ‘I’ll go blank’, ‘they’ll think I’m useless’. These thoughts (the spotlight effect) amplify the nerves.

Softening them frees your voice: people watch you far less than you think.

Example

Sure people would ‘see her voice shake’, Nia asked afterward: no one had noticed a thing.

Speaking journal

After speaking, note: the catastrophe thought · what actually happened.

The spotlight effect

Remember: the audience thinks about itself, not your small slips. Note it.

→ *People watch me far less than I believe.*

Speaking as yourself

Authenticity moves people more than perfection. You don't have to play the perfect orator: a sincere message, carried by you, lands better than a recited speech.

Your message matters more than your performance.

Example

Instead of reciting, Léa simply spoke about what she was passionate about. The audience connected.

My own message

For your next talk: what's THE message you want to convey, in one sentence?

My intention

Write your intention (share, help, persuade) — it matters more than perfection.

→ *My sincere message beats a perfect speech.*

Preparing & managing the nerves

Speaking is prepared: structure (hook, key message, conclusion), rehearse aloud, manage the physical nerves (breathing, grounding), and start with small speaking moments.

Preparation turns nerves into energy.

Example

By structuring her talk into 3 points and rehearsing aloud, Sofia spoke with ease.

My structure

Write: my hook · my 2-3 key points · my conclusion.

My anti-nerves ritual

Note what calms you before (breathing, grounding, warming up your voice).

→ *Prepared, I turn nerves into presence.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Structure: a hook, a key message, 2-3 points, a conclusion.
- Rehearse aloud (not just in your head).
- Breathe beforehand (slow cycle), ground your feet.
- Look at a few friendly faces, not the crowd.
- Slow your pace and allow yourself pauses.
- Start small (one comment in a meeting): nerves fade with practice.

To fill in

Speaking journal

Date	The catastrophe thought	What actually happened

My structure

Hook	Key message / points	Conclusion

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Understand my fear of the gaze.

Week 2 — Defuse the thoughts that paralyze.

Week 3 — Find my sincere message.

Week 4 — Prepare & manage the nerves.

Your plan in 3 lines

- The talk I'm preparing:
- My message in one sentence:
- My anti-nerves ritual:

TO CLOSE

Your message matters more than your performance — dare it.

Your message matters more than your performance.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not a substitute for therapy. If you are going through a hard time, please reach out to a professional or a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.